One night, before I fell asleep, I made myself a promise: I'm going to find a way to make that guy laugh.

23.

Like me, Marko had a sweet tooth. Like me, he particularly loved puddings. (He always called them "puds.") So I got the idea of spiking his pudding with Tabasco sauce.

At first he'd howl. But then he'd realize it was a trick, and laugh. Oh, how he'd laugh! Then he'd realize it was me. And laugh louder!

I couldn't wait.

The next night, as everyone tucked into their dinner, I tiptoed out of the meal tent. I went down the footpath, fifty meters, into the kitchen tent, and poured a whole teacup of Tabasco into Marko's bowl of pudding. (It was bread and butter, Mummy's favorite.) The kitchen crew saw me, but I put a finger to my lips. They chuckled.

Scurrying back into the meal tent, I gave Tiggy a wink. I'd already taken her into my confidence and she thought the whole caper brilliant. I don't remember if I told Willy what I was up to. Probably not. I knew he wouldn't have approved.

I squirmed, counting the minutes until dessert was served, fighting back giggles.

Suddenly someone cried out: *Whoa!*

Someone else cried: *What the—!*

In unison we all turned. Just outside the open tent was a tawny tail swishing through the air.

Leopard!

Everyone froze. Except me. I took a step towards it.

Marko gripped my shoulder.

The leopard walked away, like a prima ballerina, across the footpath where I'd just been.

I turned back in time to see the adults all look at one another, mouths open. *Holy fuck.* Then their eyes turned towards me. *Holy fuuuuck.*